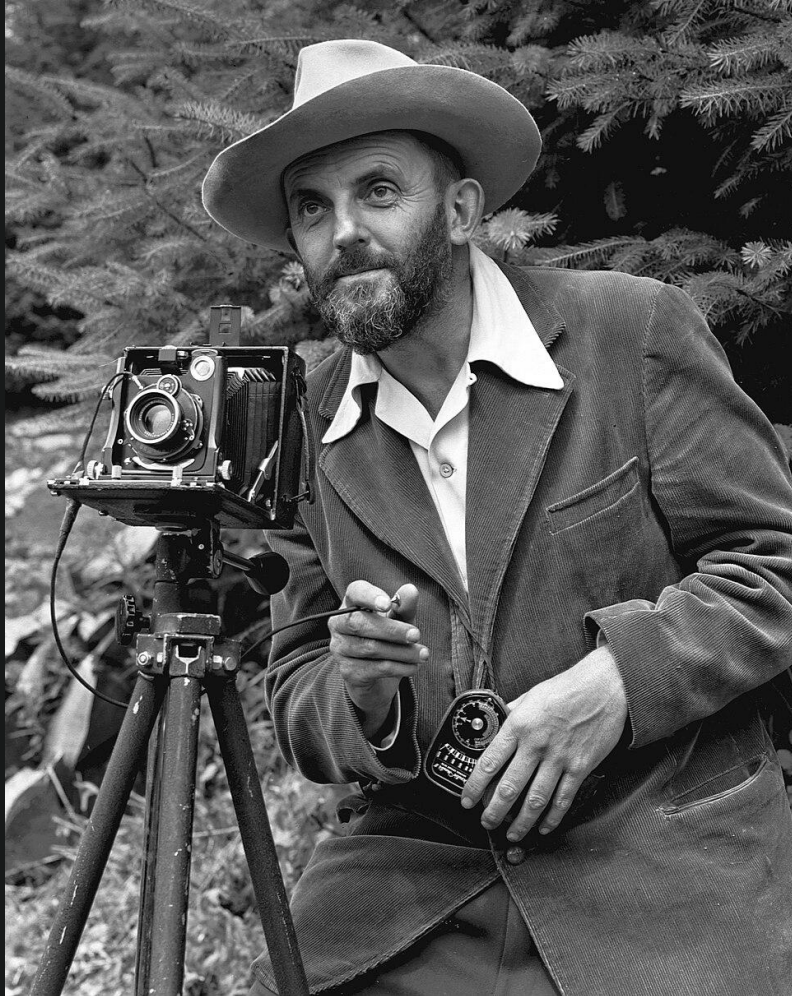


Ansel Adams: make the photograph



Photograph: J. Malcolm Greany / NPS

1902–1984

Photographer of the American West

Black, white and many grays.
Best known for black-and-white photos.
He also photographed in color.

VIDEO • 9 MIN 45 SEC

Watch the choices behind the image



[WATCH VIDEO ↗](#)

Where is the camera?

What is the light doing?

What changes in the print?

A nearby rock helps show distance

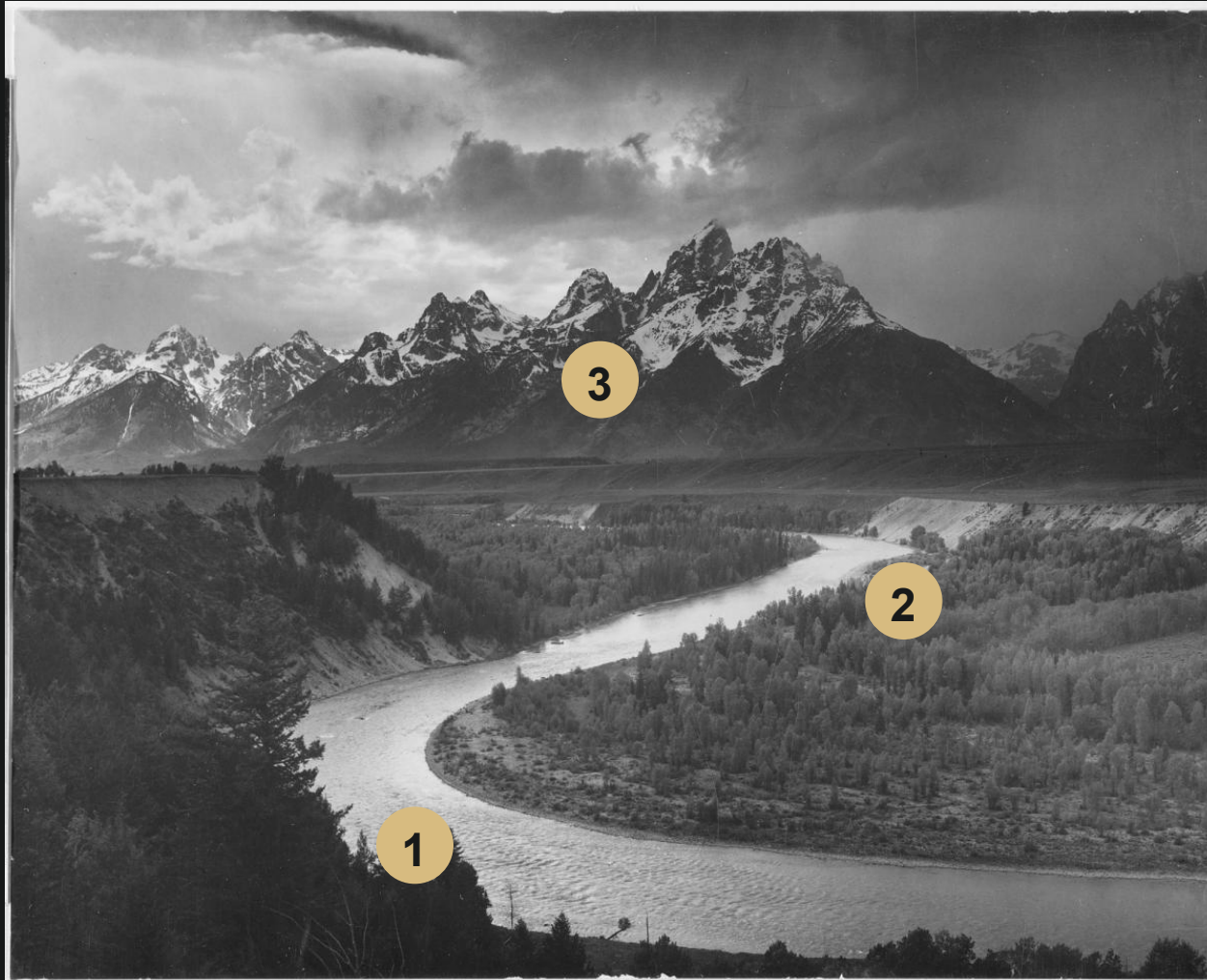


- 1 Rock close to us
- 2 Valley farther away
- 3 Mountains far away

WHY IT HELPS

The rock gives us something small to compare with the huge view. Near and far feel more separate.

The river leads us toward the mountains



The Tetons—Snake River, 1942 · Ansel Adams / National Archives

Your eyes can follow the bright curve.

WHY IT HELPS

The river connects the front of the picture to the mountains. We notice both.

TRY: Include a path in your picture.

Light and shadow make texture visible



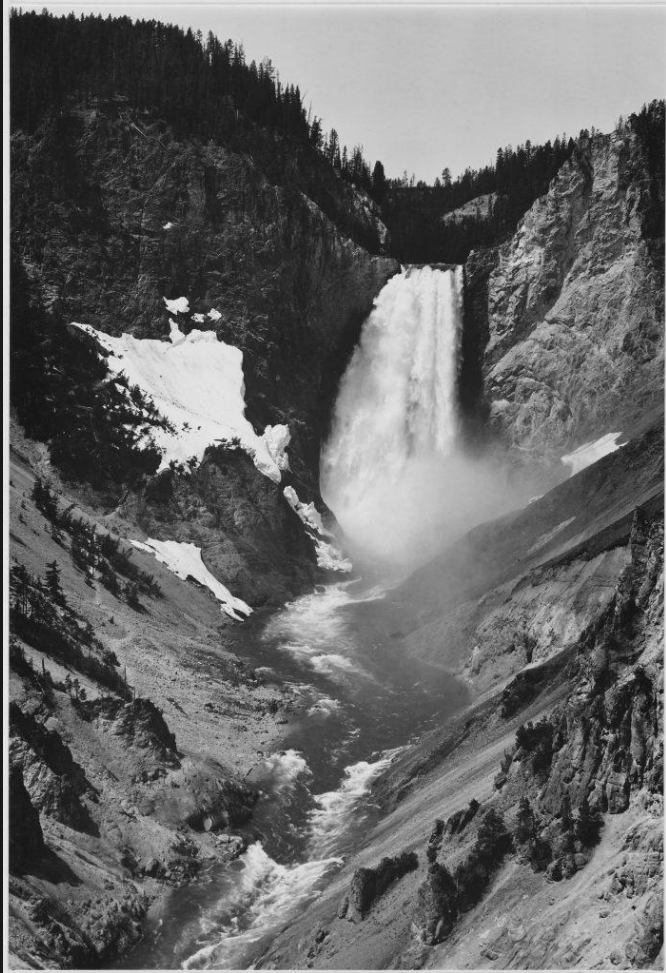
Texture means surface detail, like these leaf veins.

WHY IT HELPS

Tiny shadows beside the veins make their raised edges easier to see.

TRY: Light a leaf from one side.

Black and white still has many shades



Yellowstone Falls, 1941 · Ansel Adams / National Archives

**A tone is a shade of gray.
Different shades separate the
water, rocks and trees.**



**The aim: see details, not just solid
black or white.**

Editing can make one area stand out



Evening, McDonald Lake, 1941 · Ansel Adams / National Archives

DODGE = LIGHTEN

Brighten the lake so it stands out.

BURN = DARKEN

Darken a bright edge so it distracts less.

These change selected areas.
Contrast is the difference between light and dark.

See how the same rock changes with light

EARLY OR LATE



Long shadows show shape.

CLOUDY DAY



Soft shadows show detail.

MIDDAY



Hard shadows make bold edges.

Try a path with a rock near the bottom

HOW TO HOLD THE PHONE



EXAMPLE RESULT



1 Crouch beside the path.

2 Hold the phone sideways. Include the rock and distant trees.

3 Try early or late sunlight.

WHY: The nearby rock makes the distance easier to see.

Try a leaf on paper beside a window

HOW TO HOLD THE PHONE



EXAMPLE RESULT



1 Put a leaf on plain paper.

2 Hold the phone flat above it.
Aim the back camera down.

3 Tap the leaf on screen.
Move back if it looks blurry.

WHY: Light from the window makes the veins easier to see.

iPhone: take the photograph

WHAT TO DO

Choose Photo mode and 1×.

Turn the flash off.

Tap the rock or leaf on screen.

After tapping, drag the sun down if too bright, or up if too dark.

If the bright parts look blank white, lower brightness a little.

WHY IT HELPS

Photo takes a normal still picture. 1× starts without zooming in.

Keep the window light or sunlight that shows shapes and texture.

Focus tells the camera which detail you want to look sharp.

Exposure means image brightness. Stop when important detail is visible.

Android: take the photograph

WHAT TO DO

Choose Photo mode and 1×.

Turn the flash off.

Tap the rock or leaf on screen.

Find Brightness / Exposure.
Lower if too bright; raise if too dark.

Buttons vary by phone. Samsung: try Camera controls → Exposure.

WHY IT HELPS

Photo takes a normal still picture.
1× starts without zooming in.

Keep the window light or sunlight
that shows shapes and texture.

Focus tells the camera which detail
you want to look sharp.

Exposure means image brightness.
Stop when important detail is visible.

Make a black-and-white version

Black and white means shades of gray.

SATURATION = COLOR STRENGTH

Turn Saturation all the way down to remove the color.

WHY REMOVE COLOR?

It helps us notice light, shadows, shapes and surface detail.

iPhone: Photos → picture → Edit → Adjust → Saturation

Android: Google Photos → picture → Edit → Adjust → Saturation

Samsung Gallery also has color / tone controls. Keep your original.

Three editing words, with examples

HIGHLIGHTS

The bright parts.

If a bright leaf looks blank white,
lower Highlights to look for detail.

SHADOWS

The dark parts.

If detail is hidden in darkness,
raise Shadows a little.

CONTRAST

How different light and dark are.

Raise it a little to separate shapes.
Too much can hide details.

Make small changes. Stop when you can see the details you want.

Optional: choose one photo to try

CHOICE 1: A PATH

Find a path with a rock or plant.
Crouch and include it at the bottom.
Keep distant trees in the picture.

Try early or late sunlight.

CHOICE 2: A LEAF

Put a leaf on plain paper.
Place it beside a window.
Hold the phone flat above it.

Tap the leaf to focus.

Make a black-and-white copy. Keep the original to compare.